

How an Event Becomes a Story About Something Else

Narrative Drift, Repetition, and Meaning Loss

Reality Drift Framework — Taxonomy Note #1

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The Basic Pattern

Events do not enter public understanding directly.

They are described, summarized, interpreted, repeated, and absorbed into existing stories.

At each stage, the event becomes easier to communicate.

It also becomes easier to distort.

The core sequence is:

event → description → interpretation → repetition → narrative reality

What Is Narrative Drift?

Narrative Drift is the gradual change in meaning that occurs as an event moves through retelling, framing, simplification, and repetition.

The original event may remain real.

The dominant story about it may become something else.

The drift usually does not begin with a lie.

It begins with selection.

How the Story Changes

An event contains more detail than any account can preserve.

The first description selects what appears relevant.

The interpretation explains what the selected details mean.

Repetition removes ambiguity.

The resulting narrative becomes easier to remember than the event itself.

Eventually, people respond to the story rather than to the conditions that produced it.

The Mutation Trace

Event

Something happens in a specific context.

It contains uncertainty, contradiction, and incomplete information.

Description

The event is reduced to a report, post, headline, or summary.

Some details become visible.

Others disappear.

Interpretation

The description is placed inside a larger explanation.

Motives are assigned.

Causes are simplified.

Meaning becomes more stable.

Repetition

The interpretation is repeated across media, institutions, and conversation.

Familiarity begins to feel like confirmation.

Narrative Reality

The repeated story becomes the accepted version of what happened.

New evidence is judged against the narrative rather than the narrative being revised by new evidence.

Why Narratives Harden

Narratives reduce uncertainty.

They make events easier to explain, remember, and use.

Once a narrative becomes socially useful, correction becomes costly.

Contradictory details create friction.

Complexity weakens the story.

The narrative therefore survives by excluding what no longer fits.

Narrative Drift and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Narrative Drift occurs when the story becomes more influential than the event it was created to explain.

The representation remains coherent.

The original conditions become harder to recover.

Each retelling may preserve the main shape while changing emphasis, causality, motive, and meaning.

Narrative Drift begins when repeated interpretation becomes more authoritative than renewed contact with the event.

The Core Principle

Stories do not merely describe reality.

They determine which parts of reality remain visible.

The event happens once.

The narrative is repeated many times.

Eventually, repetition outweighs contact.

Narrative Drift is what happens when a story continues evolving after the event has stopped correcting it.

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